



We recently got our Beta 1 release of Windows Vista. Pleased as punch, we promptly proceeded to check out what lay inside the DVD. Yes, the new version of Windows ships only on DVD!

Installing It

The installation doesn't go the usual interrogatory way: it's simple and asks only for the product key, install type, computer's name and the partition you want to install it on. Here, you can create/modify/delete partitions if you want. The installation screens are extremely user-friendly.

System Requirements

Microsoft *had* warned us that system requirements were pretty heavy. Apparently, Vista requires a minimum of 512 MB of RAM. Also, if you want all the slick graphics, you need a dedicated graphics card with DirectX9 support. If you don't have one, your Vista desktop won't look as cool as it can.

The Desktop

The first thing that strikes you about the desktop is its amazing look and feel. Those who've used a Mac would readily say there's now more of the Mac in Windows.

Straight up, it doesn't seem anything revolutionary—most of the icons are from XP, but they're high-res.

There's a small button on the bottom right—the Windows Indexing Service, finally getting the front seat. MS has integrated MSN Search into the OS.

GDI vs DirectX

GDI (Graphics Device Interface) is the standard that Windows uses for creating graphical objects and putting them on displays and printers. Now, the reason why it's DirectX that is used for high-end gaming is because it lets programmers use a lot more of the features that the hardware supports. If you have a DirectX9-compliant card, Vista will use the DirectX API as far as possible, rather than the GDI API. It'll look pretty much like XP if you don't.



Vista's Start Menu

Using Vista

The way the startup menu works has changed. Firstly, there's a small search box in case you have too many programs and don't want to scroll. It finds as you type. When you click the 'All Programs' option, there's no new pane that slides out; instead, the pane on the left switches to the entire list of programs, and clicking on a folder opens it up à la Explorer.

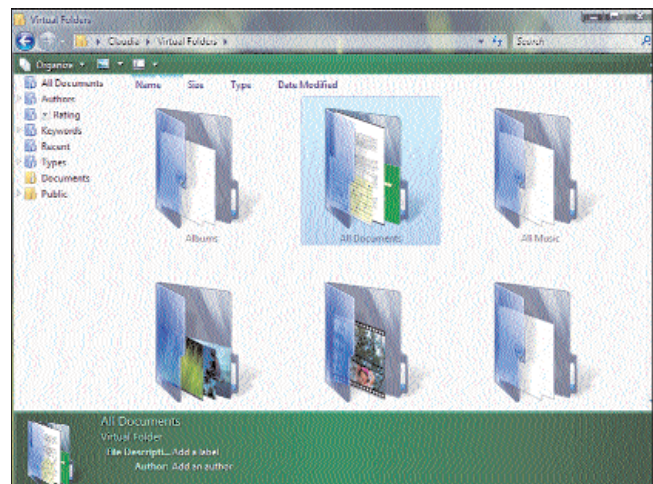
Other changes include the lack of the 'My' prefix for any of the links—so 'My Computer' is now just 'Computer', and so on. Also, the Log Off and

Shutdown buttons have been improved.

Here are some more features:

Virtual Folders

Virtual folders are basically specially-formatted XML files that act as regular folders. These folders contain search results. You can create virtual folders of your own searches. That is, if you have properly tagged music, video, documents, etc.—in other words, if the folders you're searching in contain the necessary metadata—you can save the search as a virtual folder.



Live Icons in Windows Vista



Virtual Folders in Windows Vista

Internet Explorer 7

IE7 installs by default. It's got tabbed browsing (finally!), an RSS reader and the 'Shrink to Fit' printing feature.



Live Icons

If you have an Images folder, the folder will show up with images lined up like pages. The same applies for documents, music and video folders.

Security

A recent outcry about the first virus for Vista that exploited a security hole in the command shell (MSH, probably for Microsoft Shell) bundled with it has been largely unthreatening, as Vista Beta 1 does not ship with it—nor is there any confirmation that the final release will have it.

Finally...

At this juncture, Vista looks cool, more like a Mac, but only more user-friendly! There are still some hiccups to smoothen out, and compared to Windows XP, the changes visible are more in the GUI than anywhere else. We suggest you wait and watch this space for the next update.

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